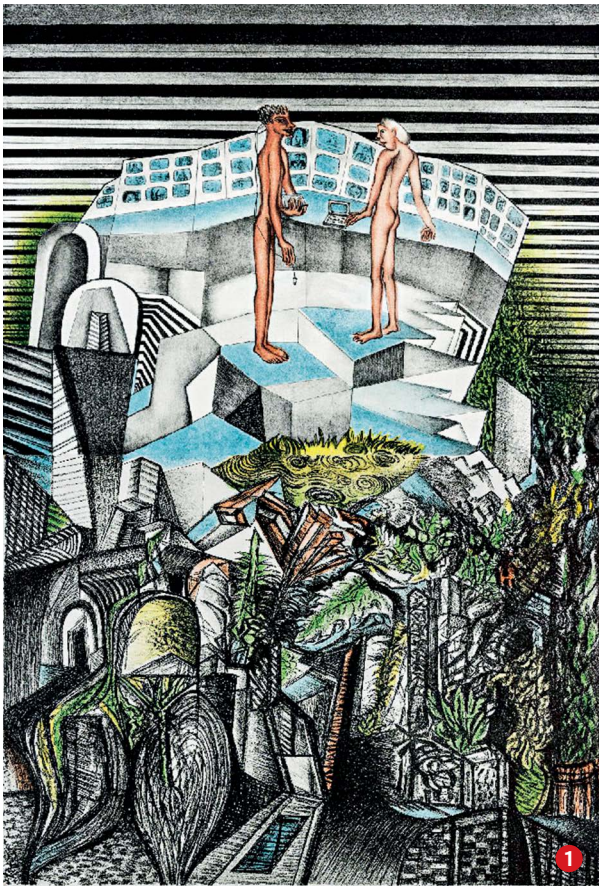
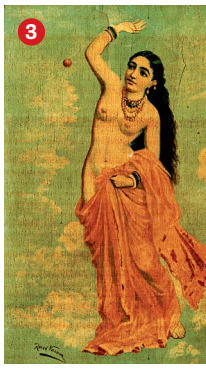
EXHIBITION

THE MAKING OF AN ART FORM

A new exhibition brings together diverse works of printmaking by contemporary practitioners and the greats from earlier eras







Courtesy: DHOOMIMAL GALLERY COLLECTION

IN the foreground of Sushanta Guha's 2018 lithograph 'Download from Life', there are two naked human figures standing before a thousand screens; one of them has their brain hooked up with wires that lead to nowhere. They're standing atop a network of stairways that evoke the Dutch artist M.C. Escher's iconic lithograph 'Relativity' (1953). And underneath the stairways lies flamboyant, unruly Amazonian foliage, the remnants of what was trampled to create the 'digital city' above. Guha's lithograph, with its impeccable technique and its haunting imagery, is one of several striking prints that make up *Of Divergent Practices: The Trajectory of Printmaking*, a new exhibition at Delhi's Dhoomimal Gallery curated by Ina Puri and designed by Reha Sodhi (on till May 10).

As Puri writes in her curatorial note, the participating artists—Anandamoy Banerji, Dattatraya Apte, Kavita Nayar, Moti Zharotia and Sushanta Guha—had worked together through the '90s and 2000s as part of a collective that was "determined to showcase printmaking and towards this goal, worked single-mindedly". *Of Divergent Practices* brings together some of their best works, alongside selections from Dhoomimal's archive. These include prints by F.N. Souza, M.F. Husain (a self-portrait, no less) Chittaprosad Bhattacharya (his 'Harvest', included here, is a stunning woodcut), Anupam Sud and many others.

The exhibition **OF DIVERGENT PRACTICES: The Trajectory of Printmaking** is on display at Delhi's Dhoomimal Gallery till May 10

"It's this combination of the old and the new that makes this exhibition special," Puri said during a telephonic interview. "On the one hand, you have all these contemporary practitioners with such a diversity of styles. These artists have worked together for many years, but they have always followed their own ideas and there's very little cross-influence. And on the other hand, you have a Husain, a Souza, a Lalu Prasad Shaw, all of these greats from earlier eras. So, at some level, their presence makes this a more complex exhibition."

Printmaking, especially the older techniques such as woodcuts, has always been an important way to democratise art and make it a little more mainstream. As Puri noted, entering an art gallery for the first time can be an intimidating experience for the average person. With prints that make their way onto, say, calendars or swag bags or casual clothes, art reaches the people on their terms. Pre-World War II woodcut masters like Lynd Ward or Frans Masereel are today considered some of the first graphic novelists, their silent woodcut picture-books considered pioneering masterpieces of the medium.

"One of the challenges before us is to inform and educate the public about the nature of printmaking as an